

Early October · 5–7 days

Trekking Italy

Six hand-picked routes — from the Dolomites and the Ligurian coast to Tuscany, the Amalfi cliffs and wild Sardinia. Pick the one that fits the group, and let's lock dates.

 Best window: 1–15 October · golden light, empty trails

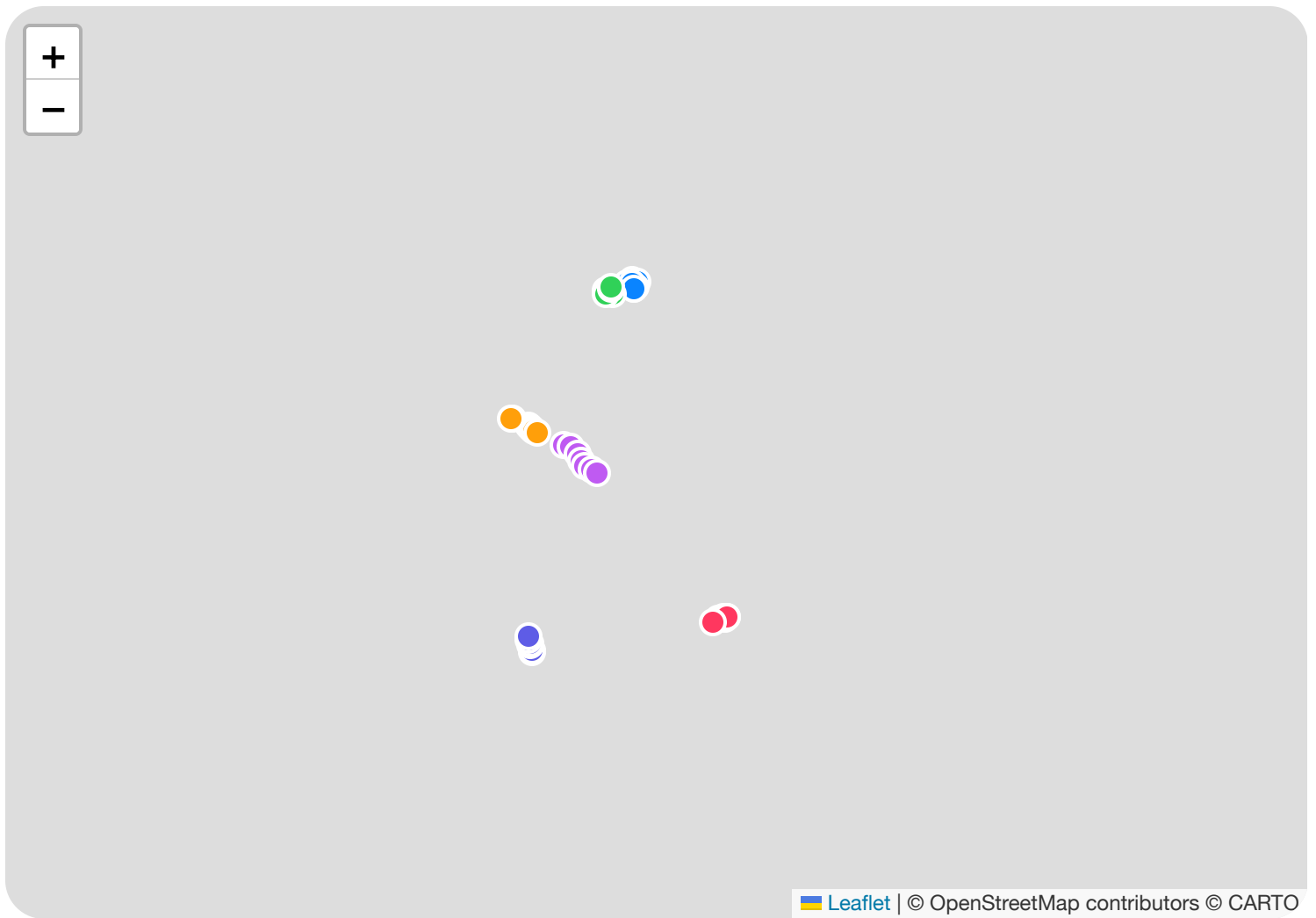
Why October?

Early October is a sweet spot across Italy: golden larches and crisp light in the Dolomites, warm sun and harvest season on the coast and in Tuscany, and blissfully quiet trails everywhere after the summer crowds. The one catch is altitude — high mountain huts (*rifugi*) start closing in late September, so the routes below are all built around sleeping in towns and hotels rather than huts.

Planning note. The classic Dolomites hut-to-hut traverse (Alta Via 1) was dropped from this shortlist — most of its high *rifugi* close by late September, so October is poor timing. All six options below are **town- or hotel-based** (you sleep in real beds, not huts), which makes them far more reliable for our dates. The southern and coastal options — Cinque Terre, Amalfi and Sardinia — are the warmest and most October-proof of all.

The six routes

At a glance — from the Alps to the Mediterranean



● Tre Cime / Sesto — Day hikes ● Alpe di Siusi — Gentle meadows

● Cinque Terre + Portofino — Coast ● Via Francigena — Tuscan walk

● Path of the Gods — Amalfi ● Selvaggio Blu — Sardinia

① Tre Cime / Sesto Dolomites — Iconic Peaks

Valley base: Dobbiaco or Sesto · day hikes

Why: Maximum iconic scenery, minimum logistical risk. You sleep in a valley hotel and day-hike. The Tre Cime di Lavaredo — three vertical towers — are the most photographed peaks in the Alps, and October's golden light + empty trails make it magical.

DAY	HIKE	DISTANCE	CLIMB	HIGHLIGHT
1	Tre Cime di Lavaredo loop ★	~10 km	+350 m	The three towers + Rif. Locatelli
2	Val Fiscalina → Rif. Zsigmondy-Comici	~13 km	+900 m	Dramatic Sesto pyramids
3	Lago di Braies + Croda del Becco view	~7–15 km	+100–900 m	Turquoise lake
4	Cadini di Misurina viewpoint loop	~8 km	+500 m	Jagged spires overlook
5	Prato Piazza → Croda Rossa meadows	~12 km	+500 m	Wide plateau, WWI forts
6	Drei Zinnen sunrise / Cortina day	~10 km	+400 m	Golden-hour on Tre Cime

Highlights: Tre Cime loop, Rifugio Locatelli viewpoint, Cadini di Misurina, Val Fiscalina.

Difficulty: Moderate

7–13 km/day

3–5 h walking

Daypack only

Reliable in October

② Alpe di Siusi / Seiser Alm — Gentle Golden Meadows

Valley base: Castelrotto or Compatsch · day hikes

Why: Europe's largest high-altitude meadow — rolling golden pastures under the Sassolungo and Sciliar peaks. The easiest terrain and smoothest logistics of all three. Big views without big climbs; perfect for a mixed-ability group and a relaxed pace.

DAY	HIKE	DISTANCE	CLIMB	HIGHLIGHT
1	Compatsch → Saltria across the meadow ★	~8 km	+200 m	Classic Seiser Alm panorama
2	Sassolungo (Langkofel) circuit	~12 km	+600 m	Loop beneath the big massif
3	Rif. Bolzano / Schlern (Sciliar) summit	~14 km	+800 m	Iconic plateau + Santner peak
4	Ortisei → Seceda ridgeline ★	~9 km	+300 m (lift)	Knife-edge Odle/Geisler peaks
5	Puflatsch loop + Castelrotto village	~7 km	+250 m	Witches' benches, easy farewell

Highlights: Seiser Alm meadows at sunrise, Sassolungo circuit, Seceda ridge, Val Gardena villages.

Difficulty: Easy–Moderate

7–14 km/day

2–5 h walking

Daypack only

Easiest logistics

③ Cinque Terre + Portofino — The Ligurian Coast

Clifftop coastal trails · Levanto → Portovenere · point-to-point

Why: A warm, sea-level alternative for when the mountains turn cold. Cliff-top paths link five pastel fishing villages, with the Portofino promontory as a stunning add-on. October is arguably the **best month**: mild temperatures, harvest season (grapes, pesto, focaccia), swimmable-ish sea, and a fraction of the summer crowds. The most weather-proof and scenic of the warm options.

DAY	HIKE	DISTANCE	CLIMB	HIGHLIGHT
1	Levanto → Monterosso (coastal path)	~7 km	+500 m	First view of the villages
2	Monterosso → Vernazza → Corniglia ★	~9 km	+600 m	The classic clifftop trail
3	Corniglia → Manarola → Riomaggiore	~8 km	+500 m	Vineyard terraces over the sea
4	Riomaggiore → Portovenere (high trail)	~12 km	+700 m	Ridge views, Byron's Grotto
5	Portofino → San Fruttuoso abbey ★	~10 km	+600 m	Secluded abbey cove
6	Portofino promontory loop / rest	~8 km	+400 m	Lighthouse & harbour

Highlights: The five villages cliff path, Portovenere, Portofino → San Fruttuoso abbey, sciacchetrà wine, seafood & pesto.

Difficulty: Easy–Moderate

7–12 km/day

3–5 h walking

Daypack only

Best October weather

 **Note:** Some low coastal links (e.g. the *Via dell'Amore*) open/close depending on landslide repairs — the higher trails used above are always open. Train connects all five villages, so days are easy to shorten or skip.

④ Via Francigena — Lucca → Siena (Tuscany)

Town-to-town pilgrim walk · point-to-point · ~135 km

Why: A completely different flavour from the Dolomites — a historic pilgrimage route through the heart of **Tuscany**. Rolling cypress hills, vineyards, gravel farm roads and medieval hilltop towns. You sleep in a different town every night (B&Bs / pilgrim lodgings), so there are **no huts to worry about**. It's a walk-and-wine-and-culture trip more than an alpine trek — and it's the most weather-proof option for early October (grape & olive harvest season).

DAY	FROM → TO	DISTANCE	HIGHLIGHT
1	Lucca → Altopascio	~19 km	Walled city of Lucca start
2	Altopascio → San Miniato	~29 km	Long stage, hilltop town
3	San Miniato → Gambassi Terme	~24 km	Classic Tuscan countryside
4	Gambassi Terme → San Gimignano ★	~13 km	The "town of towers"
5	San Gimignano → Monteriggioni	~30 km	Walled medieval village
6	Monteriggioni → Siena ★	~20 km	Finish at Piazza del Campo

Highlights: Lucca's walls, San Gimignano towers, Monteriggioni, Siena's Piazza del Campo — plus Chianti wine, pecorino and harvest-season food.

Difficulty: Easy–Moderate

13–30 km/day

Mostly flat–rolling

Daypack (bag transfer possible)

Most October-proof

i Note: This is the route from a friend's suggestion. It's *not* in the Dolomites — it's central Tuscany — so it offers a genuinely different style: cultural / gastronomic walking rather than mountain scenery. A couple of stages are long (29–30 km) on gravel/road.

⑤ Path of the Gods — Amalfi Coast

Sorrento peninsula + Amalfi · day hikes from a coastal base

Why: Southern Italy's most famous trail — the *Sentiero degli Dei*, a clifftop balcony path soaring high above the sea between Agerola and Positano, with lemon groves, Capri on the horizon and pastel villages tumbling to the water. Warmer and more dramatic than Cinque Terre, and October is ideal: summer heat and crowds gone, sea still mild.

DAY	HIKE	DISTANCE	CLIMB	HIGHLIGHT
1	Path of the Gods: Bomerano → Nocelle → Positano ★	~8 km	−700 m	The legendary balcony trail
2	Valle delle Ferriere (Amalfi → Pontone)	~9 km	+550 m	Waterfalls & lush ravine
3	Ravello → Atrani via the lemon paths	~7 km	+300 m	Villa gardens, sea balconies
4	Punta Campanella (Sorrento tip)	~11 km	+450 m	Capri across the strait
5	Capri: Monte Solaro & Pizzolungo loop ★	~10 km	+600 m	Faraglioni sea stacks
6	Bay of Ieranto / rest in Sorrento	~8 km	+350 m	Hidden turquoise cove

Highlights: Path of the Gods, Positano, Ravello, Capri's Faraglioni, lemon groves, limoncello & seafood.

Difficulty: Moderate

7–11 km/day

Stone steps & clifftops

Daypack only

Warm in October

 **Note:** Furthest south — more travel to get there (fly to Naples). Lots of stone staircases; can be busy near Positano/Capri even in October, but trails thin out quickly. Easy to base in one town (Sorrento or Amalfi) and use buses/ferries.

⑥ Selvaggio Blu — Sardinia

Golfo di Orosei · wild coast traverse · point-to-point

Why: Italy's wildest and most legendary trek — limestone cliffs plunging into a turquoise sea, hidden coves reachable only on foot or by boat, no roads, no villages. A true adventure. October is the perfect window: the fierce summer heat is gone and the sea is still swimmable.

DAY	FROM → TO	DISTANCE	TERRAIN	HIGHLIGHT
1	Santa Maria Navarrese → Pedra Longa	~7 km	Coastal path	Soaring sea spire
2	Pedra Longa → Cala Goloritzé ★	~12 km	Rocky, exposed	Iconic arch & pinnacle
3	Goloritzé → Cala Mariolu	~9 km	Scramble sections	Pebble-and-turquoise cove
4	Mariolu → Cala Luna	~13 km	Remote, technical	Sea caves & beach
5	Cala Luna → Cala Gonone (finish)	~9 km	Cliff path	Return to civilisation

Highlights: Cala Goloritzé, Cala Mariolu, Cala Luna, swimming in empty coves, total wilderness immersion.

Difficulty: Hard

7–13 km/day

Scrambling / some abseils

Guide recommended

Ideal in October

 **Note:** The boldest, most committing option — sections involve scrambling and short abseils, with food/water dropped by boat; a local guide is strongly advised. A gentler "cove-to-cove" day-hike version (with boat transfers between beaches) exists if the group isn't technical. Fly to Cagliari or Olbia.

Compare

Six routes, side by side

① TRE CIME / SESTO

② ALPE DI SIUSI

③ CINQUE TERRE

Region	Dolomites	Dolomites	Liguria coast
Style	Valley day hikes	Meadow day hikes	Coastal day hikes
Total (5–6 days)	~55 km	~50 km	~45–55 km
Hardest day	13 km / +900 m	14 km / +800 m	12 km / +700 m
Difficulty	Moderate	Easy–Moderate	Easy–Moderate
Sleep	One hotel base	One hotel base	1–2 village bases
October risk	Low	Low	Lowest · warmest
Best for	Peak scenery	Relaxed, mixed group	Sea, sun, food

My steer for early October. For mountain scenery, go with ① **Tre Cime / Sesto** for jaw-dropping peaks, or ② **Alpe di Siusi** for a relaxed pace. For the warmest, most reliable weather, the coast wins: ③ **Cinque Terre + Portofino** is the easy crowd-pleaser, while ⑤ **Path of the Gods (Amalfi)** is the more dramatic, iconic southern option. Pick ④ **Via Francigena** for a cultural pilgrim walk through Tuscany, or ⑥ **Selvaggio Blu** if the group is fit and wants a genuine wild adventure. (The classic Alta Via 1 traverse was dropped — October is too late for its huts.)

Distances and elevations are typical published figures and vary by exact trailheads and variants — treat as planning estimates, not GPS-exact. Map data © OpenStreetMap contributors © CARTO.

Made for our October trekking trip · pick a favourite and let's lock dates.